Township of NIPISSING
"Life the way it should be" 1888

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REPORT TO COUNCIL

Date: September 10, 2024

From: Kris Croskery-Hodgins, Municipal Administrator-Clerk-Treasurer

Re: Adding a Deputy Treasurer to the Administration Team

BACKGROUND/OVERVIEW

The municipal sector has seen a number of changes to service delivery, service demands, reporting requirements and staffing requirements since 2020 as a result of COVID and societal changes.

An Organizational Review and Succession Plan Proposal was prepared by Janet LeClair, CHRL, Stratford Managers Corporation for Council in September 2020. This report outlined a proposed structure review including a recommendation to hire one new position of Deputy Clerk/Administrative Assistant.

At that time the Office staffing included CAO-Clerk-Deputy Treasurer (3 days per week); Treasurer-Deputy Clerk (full time); and EDO-CEMC (full time).

In 2021 Council directed changes to the position descriptions and experienced the resignation of the CAO-Clerk-Deputy Treasurer.

In 2022 the position of Office Administrator-Deputy Clerk was adopted by Council and filled. This allowed for 3 full time office staff of Municipal Administrator-Clerk-Treasurer-Alternate CEMC; Land Planning and Technology Administrator – Deputy Treasurer; and Office Administrator-Deputy Clerk. This still left the 3-day coverage previously provided, vacant.

Following several changes and amendments to position descriptions, titles and positions, a Pay Equity review and position description amendment was completed by Pesce and Associates in 2024.

With the staff structure and position descriptions amended to reflect the Organizational Chart adopted by Council March 15, 2022, a review of duties, work load, operational changes and service delivery demands has been completed by the Municipal Administrator.

RESULTS

Three important areas need to be included in this review and the resulting recommendation.

Succession Planning

The current staffing structure in the Township Office Administration has three full time employees. This stems from the previous structure where the CAO-Clerk-Deputy Treasurer had over 30 years of experience to share and train. He trained the Land Planning Administrator on all planning and land requirements.

He trained the Municipal Administrator-Clerk-Treasurer on Clerk duties and Treasurer duties. This also included training on cemeteries, municipal software program and current and historical legal matters of the municipality. This also included the Human Resources component with payroll and benefit administration being trained and transferred to the Municipal Administrator early on.

The successful administration of a municipality includes a complete understanding of the demographics served; adequate understanding of the tools used to manage those services provided including software, mapping, historical issues and shared services; and political acuity.

With a staff of three, the two streams of training are being provided to only one staff member which is not sustainable nor effective for future uses.

1. Creating a full-time position of Deputy Treasurer-Office Assistant would provide one staff member to be consistently trained on Treasury ensuring continuity of financial practices and management in line with Township procedures and policies in the event of the loss of the Treasurer due to illness or attrition.
2. The Deputy Clerk-Administrative Assistant is expected to follow the land planning and use training, providing assistance and back up to the Land Planning Administrator for the same purposes.
3. This is a non-union environment and the cross-training of all administrative staff has been a practice followed for several years with great success. This was proven during COVID when limited staff could be in the office. Service delivery was not affected during the pandemic, with all staff members working collaboratively from home or on site to provide the required support to residents regardless of the department they required assistance from.

This opportunity will provide business continuity regardless of the reason for absence or lack of staff in the Township Office.

Reporting Burden/Work Load

Since 2021 the following changes have taken place within the Administration of the Township:

a) Township gained Consent Graning Authority and now provides the sole support for land consents from pre-consultation to the final deed stamping.
b) Change from the Baker software system to CGIS for cemetery administration, dog tag management, service request tracking and building permit issuance and management.
c) Baker Software will be closing and the transition to TownSuite software for tax purposes, accounts receivable, payroll, general ledger and accounts payable.
d) Increased reporting burden from the different levels of government including the updates and implementation of the Asset Management Plan including core and non-core assets and levels of service; Energy Demand Planning and annual reporting, Waste Diversion reporting and maintenance; transitioning from providing waste diversion programming of blue box to the Provincial responsibility; Community Safety and Well Being plan maintenance; as well as the required reporting for financial, accessibility, payroll, health and safety, school board balancing and remitting and grant reporting.
e) Increased pressures from legal matters, land matters and public expectations of increased levels of service and support.
f) A staff member is now appointed to each committee of Council as a secretary and a staff resource. The increased meeting demands and work demands from program expansion and creation has resulted in additional workload within the office to assist in the provision of programming and advertising.
g) Increased requirements for cyber security are affecting the workload for Technology Administrator, those tasks may not be receiving the attention required as other duties are interrupting the time allotted for that.

The Staff Report to Council dated April 4, 2023, identified a need for an additional full-time staff member in the Township Office which was to be filled by the Intern position temporarily to allow for the training of an individual and to assess the requirements covered by the position.

The workload being covered by the Intern Position has taken a lead in the treasury cross-over with AMCTO training courses in finance being successfully obtained and a successful assumption of accounts payable duties as well as other items. This position has also provided support for grant research, committee support and staff coverage for illness and vacation times. This also allows the staff to not be in a position to work alone. This has been identified as a health and safety concern in the Township Office due to the recent societal changes and increased challenges with customer support.

The Intern position has also provided support in the preparation of data for the software conversion, a detail oriented and time-consuming task with serious implications when not completed correctly.

With limiting use of outside consultants for several projects including the update to the Asset Management Plan (MFOA Amp It Up program intake 1, 2 and 3 were provided free of charge to the Township with support of a KPMG staff member for guidance), Strategic Plan update, Service Delivery Review including the use of a community survey, the costs for these required reports has been kept to a minimum; however the resulting workload has increased significantly when added to daily tasks.

Implementation of New Programming/Procedures

The following new programs/procedures have been implemented since 2021 that increase public interaction, public education and improve the municipal service delivery structure:

i) The use of CANVA for the preparation of public notices on the Township website and social media. This allows for branding of the Township from our logo and improved information sharing.
ii) Use of CGIS for service requests/complaint tracking, cemetery administration, building services and permit maintenance as well as zoning inquiries, property concerns and dog tags. This is an important tool for Key Performance Indicators and will be utilized in the Levels of Service requirements of the Asset Management Plan.
iii) Implementation of FirePro for the issuance of fire permits and maintenance of same, input of fire reporting requirements and support of Fire Department functions.
iv) New address change process that eliminates the need for residents to contact MPAC and allows the Township to act on their behalf to enact the change. This improves information sharing and provides a support service for residents.

Looking to the future we need to digitize historical records currently stored in the basement of the Township office in non-secure boxes and cupboards. The Township is required to maintain most of those historical records permanently. In the event of a fire, flood or other structure altering event, those records could be lost and deprive the Township of the historical value of the records as well as have legal ramifications.

The digitizing and organizing of historical records will be a large task and require the attention of a staff member with knowledge of what is stored within the documents. This is in addition to the software conversion and training and ongoing municipal operations.

RECOMMENDATION:

In reviewing a recent market survey presented to Council, 11 municipalities were compared by population, land area and number of staff.

Municipality	Population	Land Area Kms	Total # Staff
Township of Nipissing	1769	387.95	15
Municipality of East Ferris	4946	151.94	35
Municipality of Callander	3964	102.98	33
Municipality of Powassan	3346	223.26	39
Township of Dawn-Euphemia	1968	445.14	22
Township of Chapleau	1942	13.2	19
Municipality of Huron Shores	1860	51.87	22
Municipality of Magnetawan	1753	526.31	33
Township of Faraday	1612	217.44	16
Township of Armour	1459	163.52	12
Township of South Algonquin	1055	867.73	22

In order to better compare Administrative Staff Complement, the updated report detailing 9 municipalities administrative staff structure is as follows:

MUNICIPALITY	POPULATION	Number of Administrative Staff
Township of Armour	1,459	4
Township of Bonfield	1,975	6
Village of Burke's Falls	957	5
Municipality of Callander	3,964	9
Municipality of East Ferris	4,750	7
Municipality of Markstay Warren	2,656	5
Municipality of Powassan	3,346	7
Township of Ryerson	745	3.5
Township of Nipissing	**1,769**	**3**

A review of a staff position for Deputy Treasurer-Office Assistant was weighted by Pesce and Associates during the 2024 review. The removal of the Deputy Treasurer title from the Land Planning & Technology Administrator was also taken into account during the weighting procedure, providing no change to the current wage range due to the increase in workload and responsibility to that position with the added consent duties.

Work load pressure has been a notable issue affecting current Township Administrative staff in the recent years with a marked increase in personal time required and a backlog of work accumulating. The current staffing structure versus workload is unsustainable as noted by the HR review performed in 2020 by Stratford Managers and also by E4M during the CAO replacement role in 2021. In order to maintain a sufficient business continuity plan and support for all staffing positions, it is my recommendation that Council consider a new position be added to the Organizational Chart, Deputy Treasurer-Office Assistant, effective November 1, 2024.

This position may be offered internally to the Intern currently with the Township, per HR Policy Number B 2.02.

Respectfully,

Kris Croskery-Hodgins, Municipal Administrator-Clerk-Treasurer

Township of Nipissing - Job Description

Appendix A – m
By-Law Number 2024-41

Position Title: Deputy Treasurer-Office Assistant
Department: Administration
Reports To: Municipal Administrator, Clerk, Treasurer

Position Summary

Reporting to the Municipal Administrator, Clerk, Treasurer the Deputy Treasurer - Office Assistant provides treasury support and acts in place of the Treasurer in their absence. This position also offers administrative support to the Municipal Administrator for a variety of Township duties. This position manages accounts payable and receivable and ensures accurate reconciliation and balancing of payments received by the Township. This position delivers exceptional customer service, provides prompt and thorough follow-up on inquiries from both internal and external stakeholders and actively participates in committees, including agenda preparation and minute-taking, as expected. Strong interpersonal skills, meticulous attention to detail, and effective communication abilities are essential for success in this role.

Duties & Responsibilities

Deputy Treasurer

- Assists the Municipal Administrator and performs certain statutory functions of the Treasurer as assigned.
- Assists the Treasurer with the preparation and distribution of tax billings semi-annually.
- Assists with the monthly fuel dip process.
- Receives accounts payable, codes for entry into the general ledger, enters into the computer systems and generates cheques for signature.
- Reconciles Township Visa statements.
- Creates Accounts Payable listing for Council Meetings and prepares the Council resolution.
- Receives and processes payments for municipal taxes and accounts receivable in forms of cash, cheque, debit, or electronically.
- Balances the cash regularly and prepares bank deposits as required.
- Responds to property owners' tax inquiries, payment inquiries, and tax collection policy inquiries.
- Investigates and applies for grant opportunities, including special events, infrastructure projects, summer student programs, and more.

Internal & External Customer Relations

- Responds to a variety of inquiries from internal and external customers, requiring varying degrees of research.
- Addresses resident inquiries regarding municipal services such as property taxes, landfill, recreation events, public works, and fire permits.

- Handles phone, in-person, and email inquiries effectively.
- Follows up on resident inquiries or complaints related to other municipal matters.
- Responds to Council inquiries or investigates resolutions as needed.
- Develops and maintains a communication strategy to ensure effective outreach.

Administrative Tasks

- Posts agendas, minutes, and notices to the Township's website.
- Creates engaging content for social media platforms and the Township's website.
- Monitors the Township's website regularly to ensure content is current and information is updated promptly.
- Assists with the production of quarterly newsletters to inform residents about municipal news and events.
- Processes resident change ownership requests and change of address forms, updating internal documents and notifying relevant departments.
- Provides administrative support to the Land Planning Administrator and other staff members as required.
- Prepares reports as requested by management or other departments.

Committees

- Prepares agendas for committee meetings, as appointed.
- Records accurate minutes for documentation and reference.
- Distributes relevant materials to committee members prior to meetings for review.
- Attends meetings as required.
- Responds to inquiries from committee members promptly.

Other Responsibilities

- Performs other duties as assigned.

Qualifications and Requirements

- Completion of high school diploma and an additional related 2-to-3-year program or equivalent in a finance focused program is an asset.
- Completed, or willing to complete, the AMCTO Municipal Accounting and Finance Program.
- Minimum 1-3 years related experience in administrative support.
- High Level of proficiency in Microsoft Office Suite (Word, PowerPoint, Excel and Access.
- Must possess strong writing and editing skills and the ability to work without supervision in a high-volume multi-task environment.
- Strong communication and interpersonal skills essential.
- Excellent organizational skills required, including meeting deadlines.

Township of Nipissing - Job Description

Position Title: Deputy Clerk - Administrative Assistant-~~Deputy Clerk~~

Department: Administration

Reports To: Municipal Administrator

Appendix A – f
By-Law Number 2024-25

Position Summary

Reporting to the Municipal Administrator, the Deputy Clerk - Administrative Assistant-~~Deputy Clerk~~ offers vital administrative support to the Municipal Administrator. This position assists in the preparation of Council meetings, provides administrative assistance to all departments, serves as secretary on committees, and offers support to the Planning department.

Duties & Responsibilities

Deputy Clerk

- Assists in the preparation and posting of agendas to the website.
- Collects and organizes correspondence for Council meetings.
- Conducts research on relevant by-laws and provides assistance with by-law referencing.
- Serves as backup for the Municipal Clerk during Council meetings.
- Acts as Commissioner of Oaths when necessary.

Administrative Clerk

- Responds to inquiries received through the Township's general email.
- Issues permits as required.
- Monitors and orders office supplies to ensure adequate inventory levels with regard to budget parameters.
- Creates ~~posts for social media and the Township's website to promote~~ promotional material for events and updates.
- Files correspondence and maintains organized records.
- Prepares reports on various administrative matters as needed.
- Assists with the setup and coordination of programs and administrative tasks.
- Provides administrative support to all departments within the Township.
- Assists the Land Planning Administrator with various tasks and projects as assigned.

Accounts Receivable

- Processes all payments received in person, by mail, and online for property taxes, dog tags, building permits, and other accounts receivables.
- Explains tax payments and other financial matters to residents as needed.
- Balances receivables in accordance with accounting procedures.
- Completes cheque deposits and attends the bank to process cash deposits promptly and accurately.

Committees

- Prepares agendas and accurately records minutes for meetings, for appointed committees.
- Attends and actively participates in regular meetings and provides valuable input when necessary.
- Distributes relevant materials to committee members in a timely manner.
- Responds promptly to inquiries from committee members, addresses their concerns and provides necessary information.
- Prepares programming or other materials as needed for committee activities.
- Updates and posts materials to the Township's website to ensure transparency and accessibility for stakeholders.

Assist the Land Planning Administrator

- Prepares and distributes notices to relevant parties.
- Posts important notices and decisions to the Township's website for public access and transparency.
- Assists with research and pre-consultation matters related to land planning.
- Addresses inquiries and provides support in the absence of the Land Planning Administrator.

Other Responsibilities

- Performs other duties as assigned.

Qualifications and Requirements

- Completion of high school diploma and an additional related 2-to-3-year program or equivalent.
- Completion of, or willing to complete, AMCTO Municipal Administration Program.
- Minimum 1-3 years related experience in administrative support.
- High Level of proficiency in Microsoft Office Suite (Word, PowerPoint, Excel and Access.
- Must possess strong writing and editing skills and the ability to work without supervision in a high-volume multi-task environment.
- Strong communication and interpersonal skills essential.
- Excellent organizational skills required, including meeting deadlines.

Township of Nipissing - Job Description

Position Title: **Land Planning and Technology Administrator-Deputy Treasurer**

Department: Planning

Reports To: Municipal Administrator

Appendix A – d
By-Law Number 2024-25

Position Summary

Reporting to the Municipal Administrator, the Land Planning and Technology Administrator oversees the land use planning services provided by the municipality and ensures compliance with Township Policies and Provincial Legislation for all planning matters. This position oversees all computer hardware, software, and servers are in working condition and that the security and backups of all Township data are functioning properly. This position is also the Deputy Treasurer.

Duties & Responsibilities

Land Planning

- Acts as the Secretary to the Committee of Adjustment including reviewing applications, circulation meeting notices, scheduling meetings, taking minutes, and preparing documents for the meetings.
- Works with members of the community to follow up and finalize the application process.
- Reviews and processes applications for zoning by-law amendments, consent applications, Official Plan amendments, subdivision applications, etc. to ensure compliance.
- Provides information to community members and assists in locating alternative information for recommended programs and projects.
- Maintains active contacts with relevant agencies at all levels of government.
- Keeps informed about economic and legal issues involved in land planning legislation and regulations.
- Assists in legislated updates to the Township Official Plan and Zoning By-Law when required.
- Responds to inquiries in writing, in person, and by telephone regarding land planning, zoning, and pre-consultations for planning projects.
- Accepts Shore Road Closing Applications, review for completeness, and prepare for Council review.

Technology Administrator

- Maintains, updates, and ensures compliance of the Township website with AODA requirements and current Township information and events.
- Oversees and manages procurement of computer equipment requirements of all municipal departments.
- Monitors the efficiency of the server and computer components, including backup technology, and ensures continuity to business operations.

- Maintains and updates computer programs and software requirements for all municipal departments.
- Manages and updates the municipally issued cell phones for all members of staff and Council, including ordering and negotiating agreements for updated technology as required.
- Coordinates with the Municipal Administrator for the capital infrastructure needs of the computer and technology component of all municipal departments.

~~**Deputy Treasurer**~~

- ~~Assists the Municipal Administrator and performs certain statutory functions of the Treasurer as assigned.~~
- ~~Assists the Treasurer with the preparation and distribution of tax billings semi-annually.~~
- ~~Receives accounts payable, codes for entry into the general ledger, enters into the computer systems and generates cheques for signature.~~
- ~~Receives and processes payments for municipal taxes and accounts receivable in forms of cash, cheque, debit, or electronically.~~
- ~~Balances the cash regularly and prepares bank deposits as required.~~
- ~~Responds to property owners' tax inquiries, payment inquiries, and tax collection policy inquiries.~~
- ~~Accepts Shore Road Closing Applications, review for completeness, and prepare for Council review.~~

Other Responsibilities

- Provides support and information for cemetery lot sales.
- Issues fire permits, dog tag sales, and fitness centre memberships when required.
- Performs other duties as assigned.

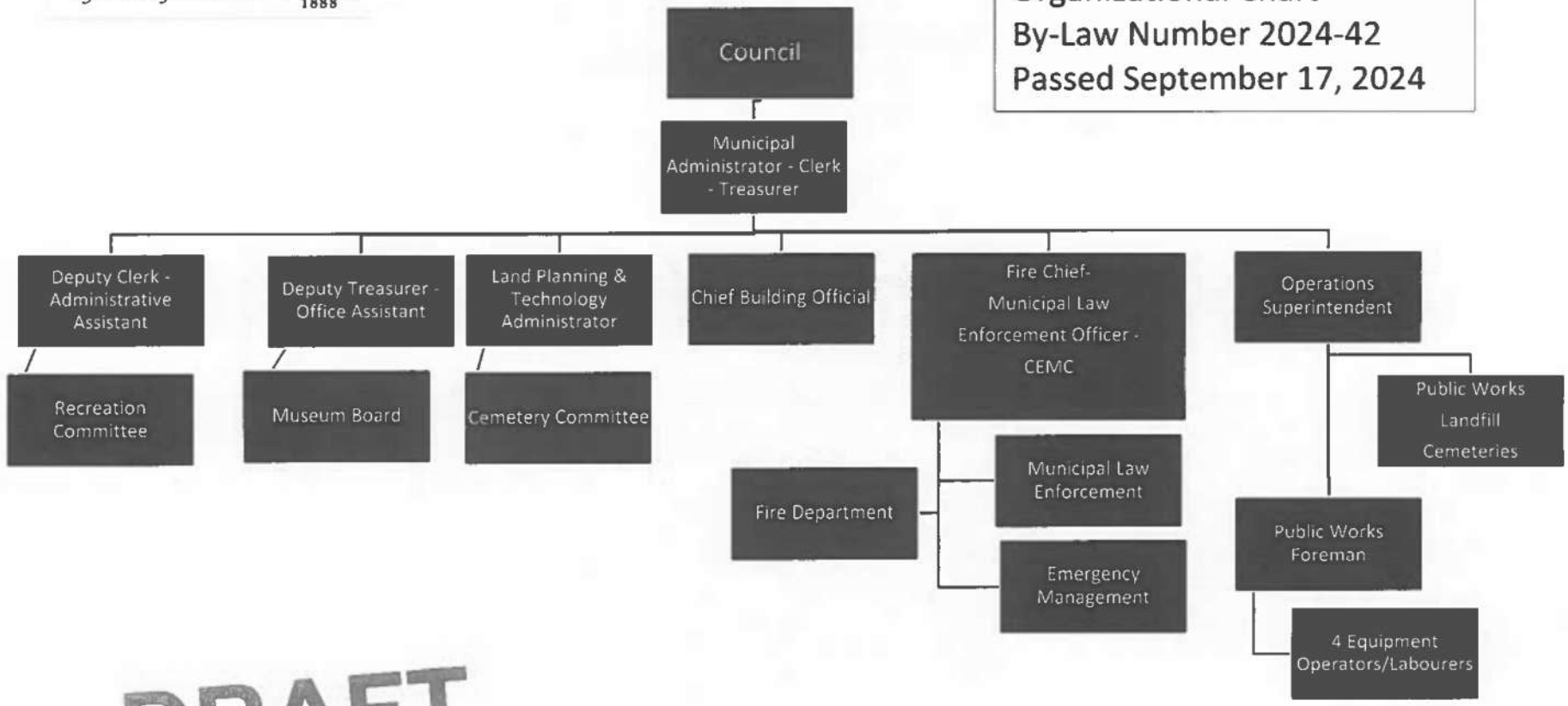
Qualifications and Requirements

- University degree or college diploma in a related discipline.
- Completion of the Primer on Planning Course.
- Minimum 5-7 years related experience.
- High Level of proficiency in Microsoft Office Suite (Word, PowerPoint, Excel and Access.
- Must possess strong writing and editing skills and the ability to work without supervision in a high-volume multi-task environment.
- Strong communication and interpersonal skills essential.
- Excellent organizational skills required, including meeting deadlines.

Township of NIPISSING

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Township of Nipissing Organizational Chart By-Law Number 2024-42 Passed September 17, 2024



DRAFT